

'For Olympic success, develop athletes as humans first'

— Abhinav Bindra



Team Sportstar

Beijing Olympics gold medallist and former shooter Abhinav Bindra said that India needs a holistic approach that synergizes sports with education to improve its Olympic success. During the Fireside Chat at the *Sportstar Focus Bihar Conclave* in Patna on March 22, speaking with Sportstar Editor, Ayon Sengupta and Raveendran Sankaran, Director General cum CEO, Bihar State Sports Authority, Bindra shared what sport taught him, how India's sporting aspirations can benefit from its Olympics bid for 2036, and what it takes to get sustained participation in sports.

Can an Olympic bid change a nation's sporting culture?

The ambition is wonderful. We are seeing early signs of legacy of the bid. We had the National Governance Act enacted, it would not have been so quick otherwise. The funding has increased. There is enough money in sport in India. There is so much going into grassroots athlete training. That has been accelerated due to the bid and we can explore other areas as well. We can go beyond just sports performance with this, in terms of what it can do for the society and act as a catalyst for change.

So you are saying it can lead to more participation in schools?

It is great that the conversations are starting. We must put together a strategy thoughtfully, because otherwise it can go the other way. I will give you an example from the

Milan-Cortina Winter Olympics. Norway won 41 medals. India has 41 medals across all Olympics. Norway has an interesting strategy, which is the childrens' rights to play. The exact policy is, 'Sport in childhood should be inclusive, enjoyable, development focused and not selection driven too early. In Denmark, for kids below 11, there are no rankings in sport'. What can we learn from this? We must ensure kids play sport. How many of our kids have access to play sports? That number is less. What is the first experience for a child? It is in school. If that experience in school is not pleasant, you have lost that kid. We have a shortage of physical education (PE) teachers in India. There are estimates of over a million but we do not have more than a couple hundred thousand in proper jobs. We need proper teachers in India. The PE teacher lies lowest in the hierarchy in a school in India. Children should look up to them. That is the fundamental start.

What you experienced as an athlete, in terms of challenges, has that changed over the years?

It is a new world from when I started. I started shooting under a mango tree. Now, the sort of infrastructure the young athletes have access to is unbelievable. We are working on improving capacity and quality of coaches, funding at the elite level in unbelievable. The amount of money spent on athletes' preparation in India does not exist anywhere in the world. In terms of funding and capacity, there is a world of difference. Sport is much more mainstream now. It is a completely different era. But that does not mean

we are there yet. We should never be satisfied, we have a lot to achieve. We should work to get better and get closer to our future aspirations.

Why do we not have enough success despite enough facilities and backing?

It is not about difficulty. The sports performance cannot be a transaction. It is never going to be that you put in an amount of money and get a vending machine with assured returns. It is far more fundamental. We must not look at it from a lens of performance. We have to look at it from an aspect of change in society. We have to improve the depth of participation and competition. The school structure has to work to get the kids to experience sport and be physically literate. That is the fundamental to sports performance. We are too focussed on the top level right now, but until we have the base of the pyramid strong, which is not based on results, and getting kids active, we won't be able to make a difference. We are a large country and have aspirations. But the foundation has to be strong and cannot be results driven. We cannot ask kids at 10, 11 to get medals. It has to be about creating a relationship with movement. I was an athlete but I was not strong, had no physical literacy. I had no access to it. So, we have to look at the base. Without it, you can create as much infrastructure but we will always be limited in terms of returns.

Was the Beijing Olympics gold medal built on your failures earlier in your career?

There are two aspects. The societal